

INTUITION UNIQUE INSIGHTS



Human Skills for the Modern Workforce:

The Definitive Guide for People Managers



Human skills are increasingly recognized as essential components for creating thriving and high-performing teams within today's work environment.

As work arrangements are now centered around remote and hybrid models, the development of these human skills becomes more crucial in fostering successful remote working practices, maintaining agile working mindsets, and facilitating organizations capable of change and progression.

Organizations who can implement effective human skills training are those capable of challenging existing norms, and **it is these organizations who will ultimately thrive in a new digital age of work.**

These skills, integral to several roles across industries, are foundational to building **resilience, sparking innovation, and nurturing intrinsic and extrinsic motivation** toward a vision for success.



The significance of uniquely human skills such as empathy, creativity, critical thinking, leadership, and adaptability has never been more pronounced, especially in a post-COVID age increasingly dominated by automation and technological advancements.

Human skills, which were before readily available through daily human interaction, are not as inherent in our daily lives as heretofore.

Young professionals entering the workforce today spent many of their schooling years in a digital environment, be that educationally or socially.

Throughout this report, you will find a series of *Intuition Insights* - unique pieces of research related to human skills we have collected from our audience.

The first of these insights can be seen below.

Are you intrinsically (autonomy, mastery, purpose) or extrinsically (money, rewards) motivated?

78%

Intrinsically

22%

Extrinsically



This report will navigate the landscape where human skills merge with professional growth and organizational innovation. It will explore the decline of human skills in digital arenas, underline the importance of resilience at work, and investigate the methodologies to bridge the educational and training gap for enhancing adaptability and creativity in the workforce.

Emphasizing a culture of continuous learning, the power of empathy in leadership, and the now essential skills of collaboration and teamwork, we will discuss how **human skills act as the catalysts for change**, driving innovation and problem-solving in the modern workforce.



The Decline of Human Skills in a Digital World

The rapid evolution of the workplace, driven by technological advancements, has significantly altered the demand for human skills.

According to the World Economic Forum, some **one billion individuals will require reskilling by 2030** due to the impact of emerging technologies on the job market. This transformation is underscored by the increasing reliance on machines and algorithms to perform routine tasks, elevating the importance of uniquely human skills such as empathy, creativity, critical thinking, and adaptability.

The COVID-19 pandemic further emphasized the necessity of these skills. Both businesses and employees alike have found human skills such as critical thinking, problem-solving, and self-management to be indispensable yet frequently lacking in what is now a digital-first workforce.

These skills are not only crucial in a digital-dominant age – they are also challenging to teach effectively, especially within the constraints of a workforce which spends large portions of its time at work in a virtual environment.

Digital technology, while beneficial in many ways, also poses significant challenges to cognitive functions. Excessive use of smartphones and the internet can lead to cognitive impairments such as **reduced attention span, memory loss, and poorer decision-making abilities, often referred to as "digital dementia"**.

Moreover, the structural and functional changes in the brain induced by frequent digital device use can affect areas critical for language and literacy, particularly in young children and adolescents.

This digital overload is reshaping how individuals process information, make decisions, and interact socially, often diminishing their capacity to engage deeply with complex concepts and maintain sustained attention.

With this remote working culture in mind, human skills have now come to the forefront of L&D departments worldwide, as they look to create a workforce (which is already digitally-savvy) capable of displaying the much-needed human skills to drive organizational change and performance.

What is your essential for successful remote working?

16%

No distractions

21%

Ergonomic set-up

59%

Self-discipline

4%

Other



Recognizing the Value of Human Skills

Recent research clearly shows the need for human skills in a modern workplace.

According to one survey, **84% of employees and managers assert that demonstrating human skills is crucial during the hiring process.** These essential skills include communication, problem-solving, and time management, which are now seen as top priorities for new hires.

Interestingly, as employees aim to progress their careers, leadership emerges as the most sought-after human skill. This is due to the natural progression toward people management on the corporate ladder.

Further insights reveal companies that actively invest in the learning and development of these skills witness a significant return on investment.



90% of global executives now agree that human skills are more crucial than ever, particularly for roles that require effective communication, seamless collaboration, and adept navigation of change in remote or hybrid work contexts.



The data also sheds light on the challenges and perceptions surrounding job readiness and skill acquisition.

According to McKinsey, a concerning **73% of employers report difficulty in finding qualified candidates for entry-level roles**, attributing this to educational institutions not adequately preparing students for the workforce.

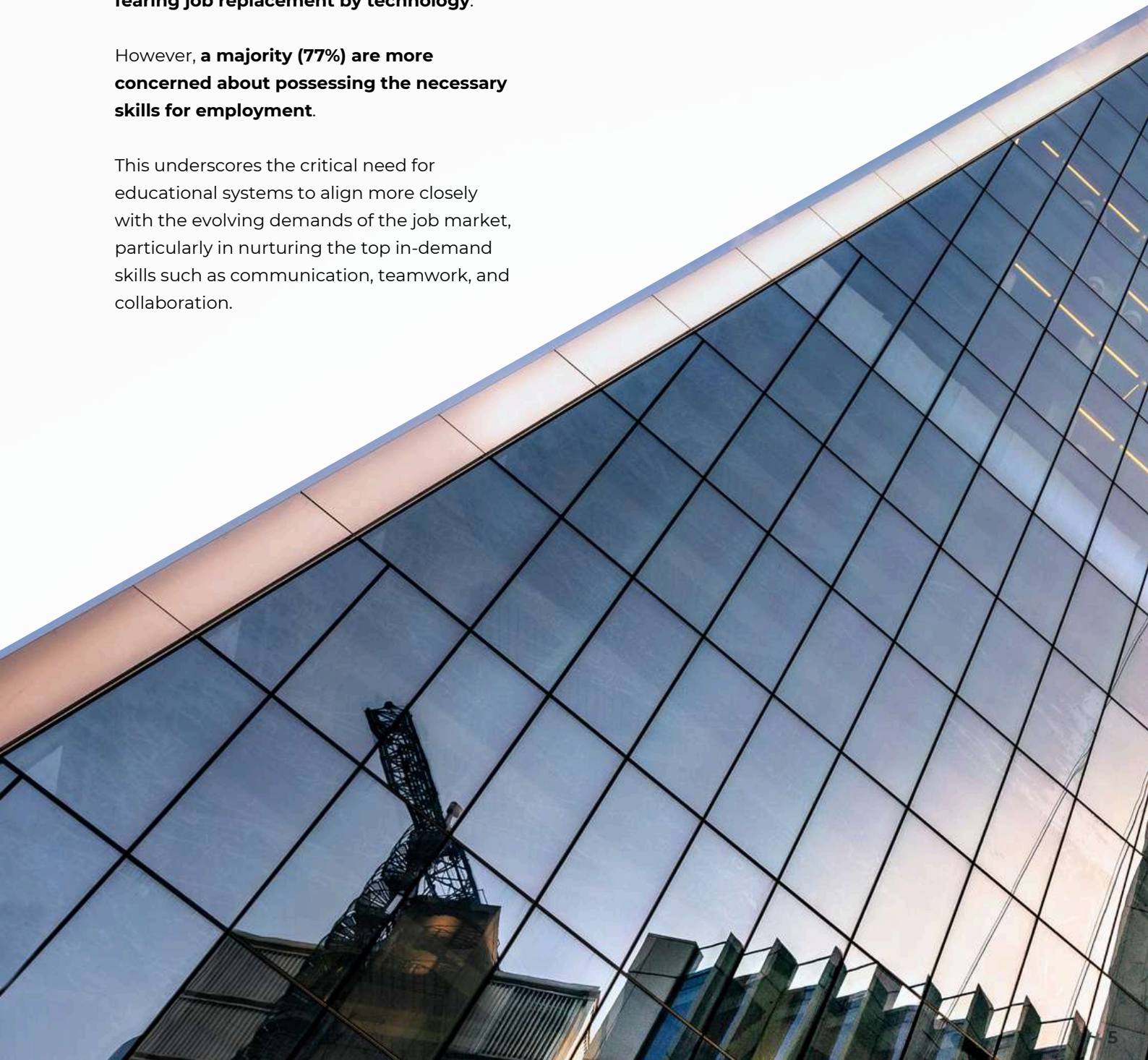
Additionally, **65% of students** believe that securing a job is more challenging now than it was for their parents' generation, with **25% fearing job replacement by technology**.

However, **a majority (77%) are more concerned about possessing the necessary skills for employment**.

This underscores the critical need for educational systems to align more closely with the evolving demands of the job market, particularly in nurturing the top in-demand skills such as communication, teamwork, and collaboration.

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73% of employers report difficulty in finding qualified candidates for entry level roles.

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Bridging the Educational and Training Gap

Addressing the Skills Gap Through Targeted Education and Training

It is clear that the education system is failing when it comes to the human skills required of modern employees. The result? Corporations must find a way to develop these skills independent of a candidate's previous schooling.

As previously mentioned, some 73% of employers report difficulty in finding qualified candidates because **schools have not adequately prepared students for the demands of contemporary jobs**. This disconnect emphasizes the need for educational systems to evolve and incorporate the human skills that are critical for professional success.

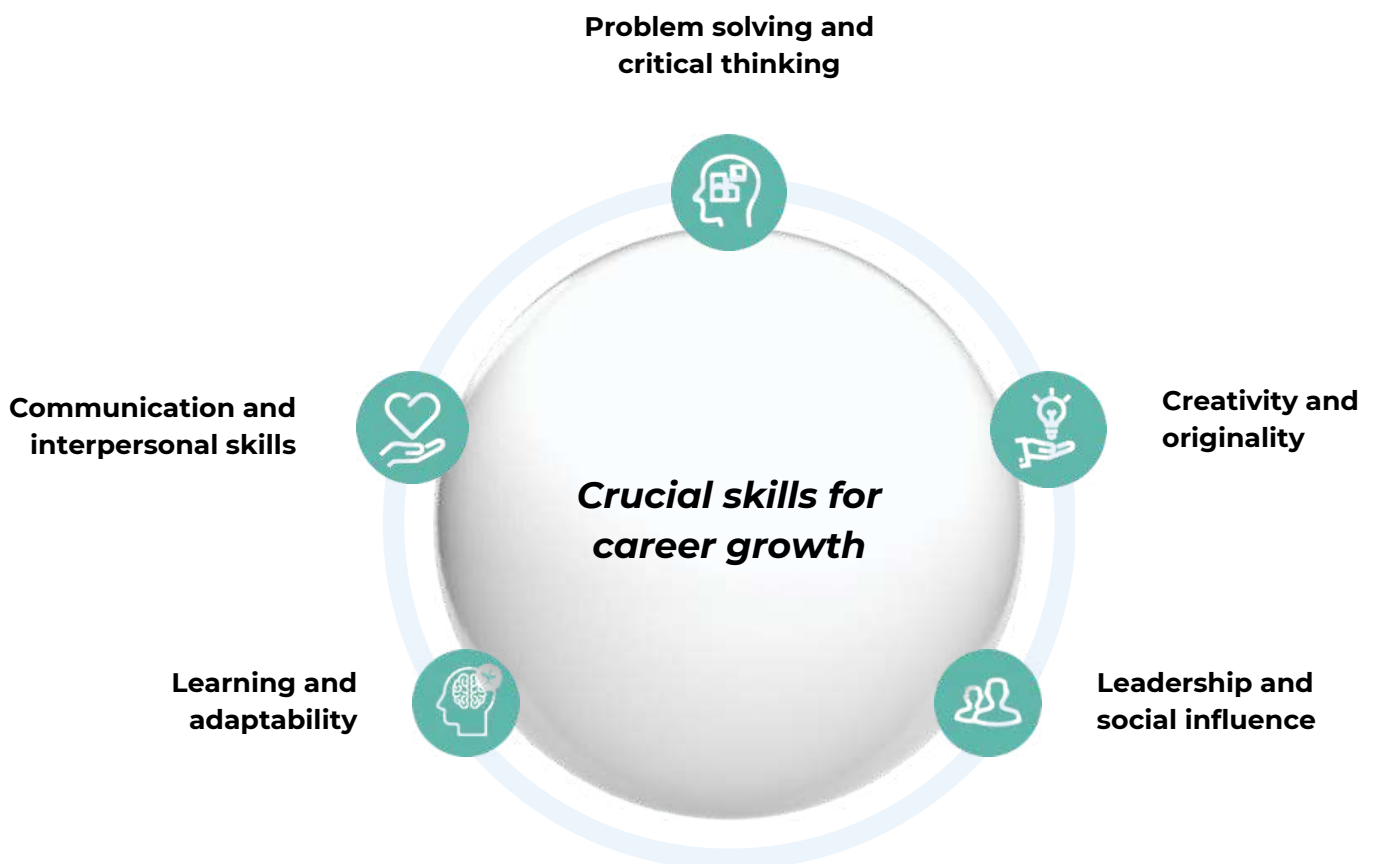
To bridge this gap, it is essential to focus on the top five skills identified as most important for career advancement and economic growth:

These skills are not only pivotal in managing and leading teams – they are also crucial in fostering innovation and handling complex problem-solving scenarios.

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Corporations **must** find a way to develop **human skills** independent of a candidate's previous schooling.

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Implementing Effective Learning Strategies

Investing in professional development through workshops, learning programs, and mentorship initiatives is crucial for enhancing these skills.

For instance, Training Industry reports that **creating smaller chunks of training content can combat the dwindling attention spans of today**, ensuring better retention and understanding.

Additionally, employing blended learning tools that include graphics, videos, and interactive elements can cater to diverse learning styles and increase engagement.

Real-world applications of learned skills can be encouraged through scenario-based activities in breakout rooms, making the learning process more relevant and impactful.

Assignments that require regular practice of these skills can help integrate them into daily professional activities, further solidifying the learning experience.

What do you think is the most important characteristic when developing an agile working mindset?

24%

Accept change positively

33%

Value teamwork and collaboration

29%

Be open to learning

14%

Accept constructive criticism



Empathy as a Leadership Superpower

Empathy in leadership extends beyond mere understanding – it involves a deep connection with team members' emotions, challenges, and personal lives, fostering a sense of purpose, community, and belonging within the organization.

Leaders who practice empathy actively listen, fully engage with their team members, and create safe environments for open communication.

This approach enhances interpersonal relationships and naturally boosts organizational performance.

Empathetic leadership is especially crucial during times of uncertainty, such as high employee turnover or supply chain disruptions. It enables leaders to be more self-aware and strategic, making decisions that are not only beneficial for the business but also supportive of their teams' emotional health.

This leadership style is not about leniency but about genuinely understanding the social issues that impact employees and addressing them in a way that promotes trust and resilience.



Despite empathy being a key skill in the workplace, many see it as an inherent trait that cannot be learned. Research from 2017, however, says otherwise.

Empathy is a skill and through targeted interventions, can indeed be taught and learned.

The impact of empathetic leadership is profound and far-reaching, improving job performance and fostering a workplace where trust and cooperation thrive.

Studies show that managers who exhibit empathy toward their team members are often viewed as better performers by their superiors. Moreover, empathy encourages a more cooperative environment and enhances decision-making processes, leading to more effective and empathetic leadership across the board.

How important is empathy in the workplace?

77%

Very important

19%

Important

3%

Somewhat important

1%

Not important





The Power of Collaboration and Teamwork

In the modern workplace, collaboration is not just a beneficial activity but a critical component of success. Human skills, particularly those that enhance interpersonal interactions, are at the heart of effective teamwork. Skills such as communication, problem-solving, and decision-making are essential as they enable individuals to work effectively toward common goals, enhancing productivity and fostering innovation.

Does your team have a vision for success?

78%

Yes

22%

No



Embracing Diverse Perspectives for Enhanced Problem Solving

One business area which has garnered significant attention recently is diversity and inclusion. In relation to human skills, diversity is of increasing importance. Diverse teams that incorporate a wide range of backgrounds and experiences are not only more innovative but also perform **up to 35 percent better** compared to more homogeneous groups.

This diversity leads to a variety of perspectives and ideas, fostering an environment where creative solutions are more likely to emerge. Collaborative problem-solving, especially in groups of three to five, often results in superior outcomes than those achieved by even the best-performing individuals alone.

Innovating with Creativity

In the realm of creativity and innovation, the integration of diverse perspectives is also of high importance.

Embracing diversity and inclusion not only brings a variety of viewpoints but also significantly enhances the creative process within organizations.

By celebrating and recognizing innovation, companies can create an environment that not only motivates employees but also inspires them to think outside the box and contribute unique ideas.

This approach fosters a culture where innovation is not just encouraged but is a standard practice, leading to sustainable growth, development, and ultimately, progress.

Strategic Leadership and Empowerment

Transformational leadership plays a critical role in driving creativity and innovation in the workplace. Leaders who adopt this style focus on inspiring and motivating employees, which in turn enhances their creative outputs.

Additionally, providing employees with autonomy and the right resources encourages risk-taking, which is an essential component in fostering creativity.

Implementing practices such as idea management systems, hackathons, and innovation labs can significantly boost creative thinking and innovation, creating a robust framework for continuous improvement and competitive advantage.



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Cultivating a Creative Environment:

- ✓ Encourage communication
- ✓ Provide creative time
- ✓ Recognize and reward

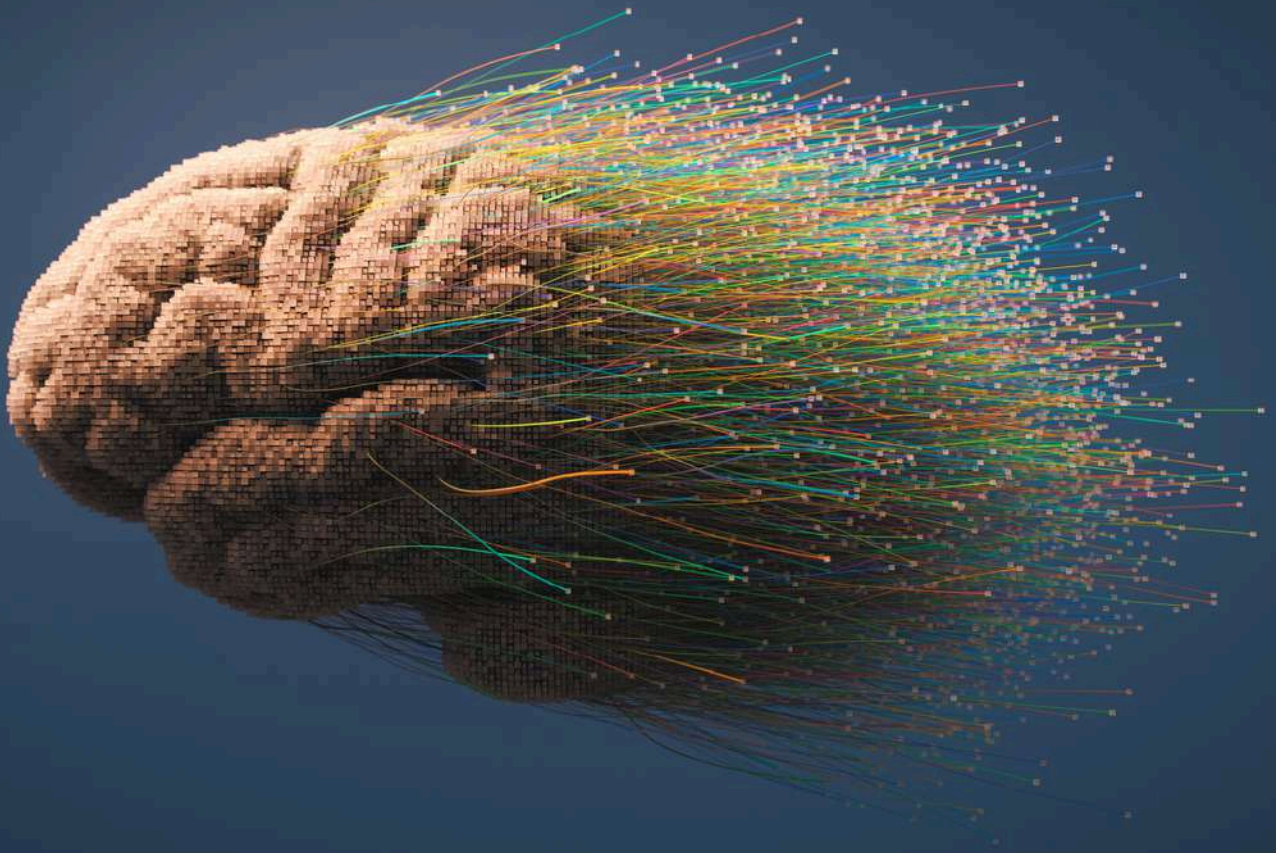
Cultivating a Creative Environment

Creating a safe space for employees to express their creativity is crucial for innovation.

Encouraging open communication and supporting cross-functional collaboration are key strategies that allow for the free flow of ideas and enhance problem-solving capabilities.

Furthermore, **providing time for creative thinking and recognizing and rewarding innovative efforts** are essential steps in cultivating an environment where employees feel valued and inspired to innovate.

This not only improves the resilience and adaptability of businesses but also addresses global challenges such as climate change and sustainable development through innovative solutions.



Building Resilience in a Changing World

Resilience and adaptability are increasingly recognized as foundational to navigating the complexities of the global business landscape.

In a world marked by rapid changes and uncertainties, businesses that cultivate these traits are better positioned to thrive.

Drift management, which involves maintaining focus and direction despite potential distractions, and meaning management, which refers to aligning team efforts with organizational goals, are critical strategies for building resilient teams.

Teams who have built these skills are adept at aligning their actions with reality, demonstrating resilience in the face of challenges, and preventing disengagement among team members, thereby ensuring sustained productivity and adaptability.

To further enhance resilience at the individual level, organizations are adopting comprehensive strategies that focus on both the professional and personal growth of employees.

This includes assessing employees' needs and providing psychological safety, which fosters an environment where staff can share ideas and concerns without fear. Additionally, offering flexibility and autonomy, supporting continuous learning and development, encouraging self-care and well-being, and actively involving employees in change processes are pivotal. These practices not only build resilience but also empower employees to adapt to evolving work demands.

Organizational resilience transcends individual and team capabilities, encompassing a broader strategic framework that integrates robust planning and proactive leadership. Building strong organizational resilience involves a commitment to investing in people, nurturing a resilient organizational culture, and leading with integrity. Embracing technology, fostering agility, and establishing proactive plans are also essential.

Such a holistic approach not only prepares organizations to handle immediate challenges but also provides a significant, lasting competitive advantage, enabling them to outperform and outlast in their industries.

How do you build your resilience during tough situations?

51%

Accept the situation

36%

Give the situation time

8%

Practice gratitude

5%

Other



Fostering a Culture of Continuous Learning

The modern business world is fraught with challenges and now moves at a faster pace than ever before. The result is a need for a more proactive approach to continuous learning – the modern employee must be capable of learning quickly to keep up with the competition.

To remain competitive and adaptable, professionals must continuously update their skills. This approach not only prepares individuals for the current technological landscape but also equips them to handle future innovations.

While this report has made it clear human skills are of the utmost importance, the next step is creating a culture of learning.

Somewhat paradoxically, learning is often given the least priority by professionals, even though organizations see this function as key to change, development, progress, and performance. There appears to be a disconnect between employee perception and organizational reality. The result is a company that falls behind others unless this issue is addressed effectively. Inclusivity and accessibility in these learning opportunities are also crucial. Ensuring that everyone has the chance to develop these vital skills can help create a workforce that is not only skilled but also diverse and representative of global perspectives.

By addressing these educational gaps, organizations can cultivate a workforce that is well-prepared to navigate the challenges of a rapidly changing world, ultimately leading to sustained organizational success and innovation.

Creating a Culture of Continuous Learning

A strong learning culture not only enhances employee engagement but also significantly reduces turnover, creating a more adaptable and innovative workforce.

Organizations can cultivate this culture by implementing strategic training and development programs, which include internal knowledge-sharing platforms, mentorship, coaching programs, and cross-functional projects. These initiatives encourage employees to take ownership of their professional growth, seek new challenges, and share knowledge.

To effectively promote a learning culture, leadership commitment is crucial. This involves embedding learning into the company's values and goals, allocating necessary resources, and integrating learning into performance management systems.

Additionally, promoting a growth mindset, recognizing and rewarding learning achievements, and encouraging knowledge sharing and collaboration are vital steps. Providing employees with flexibility and autonomy further supports this culture, making learning an integral part of daily work life.

Organizations can also adopt innovative approaches to facilitate continuous learning. Designated learning hours, flexible work schedules, and learning leave are practical strategies that help embed learning into the organizational fabric. Furthermore, internal learning events, learning pods or circles, and self-directed learning time can significantly enhance the effectiveness of learning initiatives. Protecting learning time and establishing learning days or weeks are additional methods that can be implemented to ensure continuous professional development.

What best describes your working style?



Strategies for Enhancing Human Skills

With the above information in mind, organizations can significantly benefit from investing in the development of human skills, which leads to a more competent, adaptable, and innovative workforce.

Key Focus Areas of Workplace Now

Workplace Now from Intuition is an interactive learning program designed to develop the core human skills needed for a modern workplace.

This interactive learning program emphasizes various critical areas that are vital for professional growth and organizational success:

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Workplace Now is an interactive learning program designed to **develop the core human skills** needed for a modern workplace.

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COLLABORATION AND COMMUNICATION



HARNESSING CREATIVITY



AGILE THINKING



DIGITAL IMAGE



CRITICAL THINKING



PROBLEM SOLVING



PRODUCTIVITY SKILLS



BUILDING MOTIVATION



GROWTH MINDSET



COMMUNICATING WITH EMPATHY



BUILDING RESILIENCE



HABITS OF EXCELLENCE



Benefits of Workplace Now

Implementing *Workplace Now* within an organization offers multiple benefits that contribute to a thriving workplace environment.

These include:

Enhanced Human Skills:

Employees develop crucial skills such as emotional intelligence, creativity, and leadership.

Improved Relationships:

Better communication and understanding among team members, and with clients and customers.

Increased Workplace Efficiency and Satisfaction:

A more motivated and engaged workforce leads to higher productivity and job satisfaction.

By focusing on these key areas and employing strategic measures, *Workplace Now* equips employees across all levels with the skills necessary to navigate the complexities of the modern workplace, ensuring both individual and organizational success.

[LEARN MORE](#) 

ENHANCED HUMAN SKILLS



IMPROVED RELATIONSHIPS



INCREASED WORKPLACE EFFICIENCY



Conclusion

Throughout this report, we've assessed the indispensable value of human skills in an increasingly digital world, highlighting the profound impact that empathy, creativity, collaboration, and continuous learning have on fostering organizational success and innovation.

The need for adaptability and resilience, alongside cultivating a culture of empathy within leadership, are emphasized as cornerstone principles for navigating the complexities of today's and tomorrow's work environments.

These insights underscore the essence of human skills not just as complementary to technical prowess but as essential drivers of transformative change in the modern office.

By embracing the dual pathways of targeted education and inclusive, continuous learning environments, businesses can unlock the full potential of their teams, fostering a culture that not only thrives in the face of technological advancements but also leads with innovation rooted in human connection and understanding.

As organizations look to advance, the responsibility rests with both educational institutions and industry leaders to bridge the current skills gap, ensuring a future where the harmonious blend of human skills and technological capabilities paves the way for sustainable growth and resilience.

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*As organizations look to advance, the responsibility rests with **both educational institutions and industry leaders** to bridge the current skills gap*

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